Nikki.

FREE GUIDE · STUDENTS & EARLY-CAREER

From International Student to *Healthcare Operations*

The roadmap I wish I'd had — what to do before, during and after your MHA, and how to keep going when the job market is hard.

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MY STORY, BRIEFLY

Growth isn't linear — and that's okay.

I came from a B.Tech in Biotechnology in India, spent two years as a Product Executive at a cardiovascular medical-device company, then moved to the U.S. for my MHA at the University of New Haven. Since then: a graduate assistantship, SOHA leadership, hospital volunteering, a CAPM, roles at U.S. Renal Care and Tufts Medicine, and now operations management at Medi-Weightloss®.

Year	Step
2016–2020	B.Tech Biotechnology, Lovely Professional University
2020–2022	Product Executive, Relisys Medical Devices (Hyderabad)
2022–2024	MHA, University of New Haven (3.79 GPA) · Graduate Assistant · SOHA Director of Community Relations
2023–2024	Volunteering at Yale New Haven Health · ACHE Congress program assistant · CAPM®
2024–2026	Administrative Assistant, U.S. Renal Care → Lead Admin Coordinator, Tufts Medicine
2026	Operations Manager, Medi-Weightloss® Thousand Oaks

Some transitions were exciting. Others were unexpected and exhausting. Along the way I learned that stability doesn't always mean having everything figured out — sometimes it means trusting yourself to navigate the unknown.

Resilience
Rebuilding when things don't go to plan.

Adaptability
Finding opportunity in unfamiliar places.

Independence
Making decisions and trusting them.

Perspective
Setbacks don't define the destination.

THE ROADMAP

Four phases

01 Before you arrive

- [ ] Translate your past experience into U.S. healthcare language — e.g., “medical-device training” → **stakeholder education**, “registry coordination” → **clinical operations**.
- [ ] Learn the basics: how U.S. insurance, prior authorization and revenue cycle work. It sets you apart in interviews.
- [ ] Set up LinkedIn properly before day one and start following healthcare leaders and your program's alumni.

02 During your MHA

- [ ] **Join (or lead) the student healthcare club.** Leading SOHA's community relations connected me with alumni, faculty and industry leaders.
- [ ] **Volunteer inside a hospital.** It's how you learn real workflows and earn U.S. references.
- [ ] **Go to professional events** like ACHE and your local chapter — volunteer to help run them and you'll meet more people.
- [ ] Take an on-campus role (graduate assistant, department work) to build U.S. experience and a reference.
- [ ] Pick an internship or capstone with a **real operational problem** and measurable results.
- [ ] Add a credential that signals structure — I chose **PMI's CAPM**.

03 The job search

- [ ] Expect a long process: multi-month timelines and many interview rounds are common. Plan for it, don't take it personally.
- [ ] Apply to **front-line operations roles** too (patient access, scheduling, coordination). They teach the system from the ground up.
- [ ] Quantify everything on your resume — see the companion *Resume & LinkedIn Kit*.
- [ ] Ask for 2–3 sentences of feedback after interviews; it turns rejection into growth.
- [ ] Talk to your school's international student office early about work-authorization timelines.

04 Your first 90 days

- [ ] Learn every step of the patient journey in your area — sit with front desk, billing and clinical staff.
- [ ] Find one process that frustrates people and quietly fix it with data.
- [ ] Keep a "wins" document with numbers. It becomes your next resume and your review.
- [ ] Share what you're learning on LinkedIn — it builds your reputation and network.

> *"The market rewards persistence more than perfection. Community beats competition every time. Your timeline ≠ your worth."*

When it gets hard

- Build a small support circle of classmates who are job-hunting too — share leads and review each other's resumes.
- Keep one thing you control moving every week: a course, a project, a coffee chat.
- Celebrate small wins. Growth isn't always linear, and setbacks don't define the destination.

A note on visas and work authorization: rules change and depend on your situation. Always confirm with your school's international student office (DSO) or an immigration attorney — not social media.

NEXT STEP

Navigating this right now? *Let's talk.*

I'm always happy to help fellow international students and early-career professionals in healthcare operations and administration. Book a free 30-minute mentoring chat — bring your questions, your resume or your plan.

Session	Length	Price	Best for
Intro call	15 min	Free	Say hello and see if we're a fit.
Mentoring chat	30 min	Free	Career questions, MHA advice or a resume review.
Working session	60 min	On request	A focused session on your clinic or project.

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About Nikki. Nikhila (Nikki) Mamanduri is a Healthcare Operations Manager at Medi-Weightloss® Thousand Oaks with an MHA from the University of New Haven (3.79 GPA) and PMI's CAPM®. She has worked across medical devices (Relisys), dialysis (U.S. Renal Care), academic medicine (Tufts Medicine) and clinic operations, and believes better systems create stronger teams — and a better experience for every patient.

This guide shares general operational practices for educational purposes. It isn't legal, billing-compliance, immigration or medical advice — check payer rules, your organization's policies and the relevant authorities for your situation.